PADHAKU
Exploring Society: India and Beyond · Class 6 Social Science



CHAPTER 4

Timeline and Sources of History

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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🤔 How Do We Learn About the Past? · Think About It

1 **What is the earliest memory you can recollect? Do you remember how old you were at that time?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

My earliest memory is of my first day at school, holding my mother's hand at the gate.

I was about 3 or 4 years old then.

Such memories are a part of my own past, going back 5 or 6 years.

2 **How do you think understanding the past will help us understand the present world?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- The past tells us how today's customs, languages, villages and cities began.
- It shows how people solved problems earlier, so we can learn from their successes and mistakes.
- As E.H. Carr said, we can fully understand the present only in the light of the past.

⭐ How Is Time Measured in History? · Let's Explore

? **560 BCE is an approximate year of birth of Gautama Buddha. Can you calculate how many years ago that was?**

✔ ANSWER

There is no 'year zero', so add the two years and subtract 1.

Taking the present year as 2024 CE:

560 + 2024 − 1 = **2,583 years ago**.

1 **Draw a simple timeline marking every year from 2 BCE to 2 CE.**

✔ ANSWER

2 BCE → 1 BCE → 1 CE → 2 CE

There is no year 0 between 1 BCE and 1 CE.

So only **3 years** have passed: 2 + 2 − 1 = 3.

2 **Practice a few examples with your classmates (years between a BCE date and a CE date).**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Rule: BCE year + CE year − 1.

- From 100 BCE to 100 CE: 100 + 100 − 1 = **199 years**
- From 323 BCE to 2024 CE: 323 + 2024 − 1 = **2,346 years**
- From 1 BCE to 1 CE: 1 + 1 − 1 = **1 year**

⭐ Don't Miss Out · Century and Millennium

? **In the timeline given on pages 62 and 63 (Fig. 4.3), can you mark the beginning of the 8th millennium BCE?**

✔ ANSWER

The 1st millennium BCE is 1 BCE to 1000 BCE; counting back, the 8th millennium BCE is 8000 BCE to 7001 BCE.

Since BCE time runs forward from 8000 BCE towards 7001 BCE, it **begins in 8000 BCE**.

Mark it at **8000 BCE**, between the 10,000 BCE and 6000 BCE marks on the timeline.

Let's Explore · Family Timeline

1 **Create a timeline stretching from 1900 CE to the current year and place the dates of birth of your grandparents, parents, siblings and yourself. Also, mark the years that the 20th century CE begins with and ends with.**

SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample timeline:

1900 — **1901 (20th century begins)** — 1955 Grandfather born — 1960 Grandmother born — 1985 Father born — 1988 Mother born — **2000 (20th century ends)** — 2010 Elder sister born — 2014 Me — 2024 (now)

The 20th century CE runs from **1901 to 2000**.

What Are the Sources of History?

Let's explore **Collect information about at least three generations of your family on your mother's and father's sides. Create a family tree (relation, name, occupation, place of birth, source of information).**

SAMPLE ANSWER

Relation	Name	Occupation	Place of birth	Source of information

Grandparents (paternal)	Ram Prasad, Sita Devi	Farmer, homemaker	A village in Bihar	Father, old photographs
Grandparents (maternal)	Mohan Lal, Kamla Devi	Teacher, tailor	Kanpur	Mother, school certificate
Great-grandparents (paternal)	Shiv Prasad, Gauri Devi	Farmer	Same village	Grandmother's memories
Great-grandparents (maternal)	Hari Lal, Parvati	Shopkeeper	Kanpur	Old letters, uncle

(Fill in your own family's details.)

? **How did you find details about your family's past? Did you rely on things like photographs, diaries, ID cards or memories from your parents and relatives?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

I asked my parents and grandparents (memories).

I also looked at old photographs, ID cards, certificates and letters kept at home.

Think about it **Have you ever seen old coins, books, clothes, jewellery or utensils in and around your house? What type of information can we gain from such objects? Or from old houses or buildings?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Coins: who ruled, when, and what was used in trade.
- Books: what people knew, believed and the language they wrote in.
- Clothes and jewellery: fashion, skills of weavers and craftsmen, and the materials available.
- Utensils: what people cooked and ate, and the metals they used.
- Old houses and buildings: building materials, skills, and how people lived.

Let's explore

There are a few images of different sources of history on the next page. Who and what do you think the objects show? Write down any information that you get from these objects.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Look at each image and note: what it is (coin, inscription, sculpture, pot, painting...), who or what it shows (a king, a god, an animal, a scene), and what it tells us (rulers, beliefs, trade, art, daily life).

Example: a coin with a king's face tells us the king's name, that he ruled, and that coins were used in trade.

(check the picture in your book)

⭐ The Beginnings of Human History

Let's explore **In the picture, look at some activities of early humans in a rock shelter. Which ones can you recognise? Give a brief description for each.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Painting on the rock wall: drawing animals and humans with colours.
- Making stone tools: shaping stone axes, blades and arrowheads.
- Using fire: for warmth, cooking and keeping animals away.
- Hunting and bringing back animals; gathering fruits and plants.
- Making beads or ornaments from stone, shells or animal teeth.

(check the picture in your book)

Let's explore **Observe the scene. It depicts an agricultural community from a few millenniums ago. List the main activities you can identify.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Ploughing and sowing fields; harvesting crops.
- Looking after domesticated animals like cattle and goats.
- Making pots (pottery).
- Grinding grain and cooking.
- Building houses near a river; fetching water.

(check the picture in your book)

Think about it **In both pictures, men and women are given certain roles. Keeping in mind that we have only limited information, think about such roles and situations, and discuss in class.**

SAMPLE ANSWER

The pictures are only guesses made from limited evidence.

Work was probably shared: women may have hunted, painted or made tools; men may have cooked and looked after children.

So we should not assume that the roles shown were fixed or 'natural' for everyone.

Questions, Activities and Projects

1 **As a project, write the history of your family (or village if you live in one), using sources of history at your disposal.**

SAMPLE ANSWER

Steps:

- Talk to elders (oral source) and note names, dates, places and work.
- Look at old photographs, documents, letters, coins or objects at home.
- Arrange the events on a timeline.
- Write a short account, e.g. "My great-grandfather came to this village around 1940 and started farming. My grandfather became the first teacher in the village school..."
- Mention the sources you used.

2 **Can we compare historians to detectives? Give reasons for your answers.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes.

- Like detectives, historians collect clues (sources: coins, inscriptions, texts, remains).
- They check whether the clues match or contradict each other, like jigsaw pieces.
- They decide which source to trust more.
- Then they put the pieces together to re-create what happened in the past.

3 (i) **Place these dates chronologically on the timeline: 323 CE, 323 BCE, 100 CE, 100 BCE, 1900 BCE, 1090 CE, 2024 CE.**

✔ ANSWER

1900 BCE → 323 BCE → 100 BCE → 100 CE → 323 CE → 1090 CE → 2024 CE

(BCE dates: bigger number is earlier; CE dates: smaller number is earlier.)

3 (ii) **If King Chandragupta was born in 320 CE, which century did he belong to? And how many years was that after the Buddha's birth?**

✔ ANSWER

The 4th century CE runs from 301 to 400, so he belonged to the **4th century CE**.

Buddha born 560 BCE. Years between: 560 + 320 − 1 = **879 years** after the Buddha's birth.

3 (iii) **Rani of Jhansi was born in 1828. Which century did she belong to? How many years was that before India's Independence?**

✔ ANSWER

The 19th century CE runs from 1801 to 1900, so she belonged to the **19th century CE**.

1947 − 1828 = **119 years** before India's Independence.

3 (iv) **Turn '12,000 years ago' into a date.**

✔ ANSWER

Taking the present year as 2024 CE:

BCE year + 2024 − 1 = 12,000

BCE year = 12,000 − 2024 + 1 = 9,977

So 12,000 years ago = **9977 BCE**, i.e. **about 10,000 BCE**.

4 **Plan a visit to a nearby museum, with some prior research on its exhibits. Keep notes during the visit. Write a brief report afterwards, highlighting what was unexpected / interesting / fun.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample report: "Our class visited the National Museum, New Delhi. Before the visit we read that it has statues, coins and ornaments. The most interesting exhibit was a gallery of Harappan objects — seals, beads and toys made over 4,000 years ago. It was unexpected to see how small and neat the beads were. The fun part was a model of an ancient city. We learnt that museums preserve objects that help us understand our history."

5 **Invite to your school an archaeologist or a historian and ask them to speak on the history of your region and why it's important to know it.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- With your teacher, write a polite invitation letter or email to a historian or archaeologist (from a nearby university, museum or the Archaeological Survey of India).
- Prepare questions: Which old sites are in our region? What do they tell us? Why should we know our local history?
- After the talk, write a short summary and thank the speaker.

🎉 **Chapter 4 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**